Handle With Care

By Jodi Picoult

Charlotte (Mom): (Pg 403) The movie that had been filmed to show a day in your life was the last bit of evidence that Marin would offer to the jury. It was the emotional counterpart to the cold, hard facts the actuary had given, about what it costs in this country to have a disabled child.

It began with an image of your face, reflected in the windowpane you were peering through. You weren't speaking, but you didn't have to. There was a lifetime of longing in your eyes.

The view panned out the window, then, to watch your sister skating on the pond.

INTRODUCTION

How far would you go to care for the ones you love? In the following selection, Willow O'Keefe is a little girl who has Type III osteogenesis imperfecta, also known as brittle bone syndrome. Her parents, Sean and Charlotte, have spent most of her life with sleepless nights, hospital bills, and stares from other parents who are luckier than they are. After going to Disney World, where Willow suffers a serious bone break, Sean and Charlotte decide to file a lawsuit against the park and the hospital, but it suddenly turns into a wrongful birth lawsuit against the OB/GYN who treated Charlotte during her pregnancy. The parents must testify that if they knew before birth that Willow had this disease, they would have aborted her. Told through the eyes of Charlotte, Willow's mother; and Amelia, Willow's sister, the trial takes a toll on their entire family. Handle With Care by Jodi Picoult.

Amelia (Sister): (Pg 17) I [can] imagine our parents saying, *There Amelia goes, being difficult again.*

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(Pg 18-19) Pick ten strangers and stick them in a room, and ask them which one of us they feel sorrier for – you or me – and we all know who they'll choose. It's kind of hard to look past your casts; and the fact that you're the size of a two-year-old, even though you're five. I'm not saying that you've had it easy. It's just that I have it worse, because every time I think my life sucks, I look at you and hate myself even more for thinking my life sucks in the first place.

Here's a snapshot of what it's like to be me:

Amelia, don't jump on the bed, you'll hurt Willow.

Amelia, how many times have I told you not to leave your socks on the floor, because Willow could trip over them?

Amelia, turn off the TV (although I've only watched a half hour, and you've been staring at it like a zombie for five hours straight).

I know how selfish this makes me sound, but then again, knowing something's true doesn't keep you from feeling it.

Charlotte (Mom): [The lawyer continued talking to Sean and me.]

Marin (Attorney): (Pg 64) I know how horrible this sounds. But the term ***wrongful birth*** is just a legal one. We don't wish your child wasn't born. We just think that, when a doctor doesn't meet the standard of care a patient deserves, someone ought to be held responsible. Think of all the time and money that's gone into taking care of Willow – and ***will*** go into taking care of her in the future. Why should ***you*** pay for someone else's mistake?

Charlotte (Mom): (Pg 60) What if it was someone's fault?

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For five years now I had loved you, hovered over you, held you when you had a break. So how could I admit to anyone – much less myself- that you were not only the most wonderful thing that had ever happened to me . . . but also the most exhausting, the most overwhelming?

Marin (Attorney): (Pg 91) If you file this lawsuit, you have to be able to swear – under oath – that if you'd known about your daughter's illness earlier, if you'd been given the choice, you would have terminated the pregnancy. Is that going to be a problem?

Charlotte (Mom): Can you miss a person you've never known?

Amelia (Sister): (Pg 121) The last time my parents had been fighting – which was, like, yesterday – you and I were in our bedroom, and we could hear them loud and clear. Words slipped under the door, even though it was closed: *wrongful birth… testimony… deposition.* At one point I heard the mention of television: *Don't you think reporters would get wind of this? Is that what you really want?* and for a moment I thought how cool it would be to be on the news, until I remembered that being a poster child for dysfunctional family life wasn't really how I wanted to spend my fifteen minutes of fame.

They're mad at me, you said.

No. They're mad at each other.

Then we both heard Dad say, *Do you really think Willow wouldn't figure this out?*

You looked at me. *Figure what out?*

Charlotte (Mom): (Pg 71) Sean was the risk taker when it came to you. Then again, he wasn't the one who was home most often when you had a break. Maybe

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I could convince him that two silly words like ***wrongful birth*** meant nothing when compared to the future they might secure for you.

(Pg 104) It's ***because*** we want her, ***because*** we love her, that I'd ever think about this in the first place. I'm not stupid, Sean. I know people are going to talk, and say I'm after a big settlement. They're going to think I'm the worst mother in the world, the most selfish. But I don't care what they say about me – I care about Willow. I want to know that she'll be able to go to college and live on her own and do everything she dreams of. Does it really matter what everyone else says if ***I*** know why I'm doing it?"

Willow: (Pg 193) *(whispering)* You know how Mom always says that I can be anything when I grow up? That's a lie.

Amelia: Why?

Willow: I couldn't be a boy. And I couldn't be Miss America.

Amelia: How come?

Willow: You can't wear leg braces in a pageant.

Amelia: *(to audience)* I thought about those pageants, girls too beautiful to be real, tall and thin and plastic-perfect. And then I thought of you, short and stubby and twisted, like a root growing wrong from the trunk of a tree, with a banner draped across your chest.

MISS UNDERSTOOD.

MISS INFORMED.

MISS TAKE.

That made my stomach hurt.

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Charlotte (Mom): [This is what I tell the jury.] (Pg 359-360) I know what I look like to all of you. I know you think I'm in this for a big payday, that this is why I started this lawsuit.

It ***is*** about cost. But not the financial kind. I don't sleep at night. *(blinking back tears)* I don't sleep at night. I feel guilty when I laugh at a joke on TV. I watch little girls the same age as Willow at the playground, and I hate them sometimes – that's how bitterly jealous I can get when I see how easy it is for them.

I made a promise to my daughter – I said, *If you fight, I will, too. If you live, I will make sure your life is the best it can possibly be.* That's what a good mother does, right? *(Shakes her head)* The way it usually works, the parent takes care of the child, until years later, when the roles are reversed. But with Willow and me, I'll always be the one taking care of her. That's why I'm here today. That's what I want you to tell me. How am I supposed to take care of my daughter after I'm gone?

Willow: (Pg 320-321) *(wiping tears from her eyes)* Mom wants to get rid of me because [I keep breaking]. I'm not the kind of kid anyone wants.

Amelia: What are you talking about? It's not like you're a serial killer. You don't torture chipmunks or do anything revolting, except try to burp 'God Bless America' at the dinner table-

Willow: I only did that once. But think about it, Amelia. Nobody keeps things that get broken. Sooner or later, they get thrown away.

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Amelia: Willow, you are not being sent off, believe me. And if you are, I'll run away with you first.

Charlotte (Mom): (Pg 442) [Amelia] asked me not too long ago what the world would be like without Willow in it. So here's what I think: if Willow had never been born, I'd still look for her in the aisles of the grocery store, or at the bank, or in the bowling alley. I'd stare at every individual face in a crowd, trying to find hers. There's this weird part about having kids – you know when your family is finished, and when it's not. If Willow hadn't been born, that's how the world would be for me – unfinished.

Amelia (Sister): (Pg 455) We all protected you, in our own ways. Dad blustered around, angry at anything that made life harder for you. Mom, well, she was apparently stupid enough to gamble everything in order to get more for you in the long run. And me, I guess I just lacquered a shell around myself, so that when you got hurt, it was easier to pretend I didn't feel it, too.

Charlotte (Mother): [The day the jury reached its verdict, I told] (Pg 465) you that this was finally over. I [told] you that you'd have everything you needed, for the rest of your life – and after mine ended. I [told] you that I had won, and that the verdict award[ed] damages in the amount of eight million dollars.

Willow: (Pg 469) Eight million is the number of dollars written on the big blue check that has been on our refrigerator for almost six months now. (Pg 471) My parents had never cashed the check. A lot of zeros didn't mean anything really, except security – my parents could splurge a little, because if their funds ran out, there was a backup.

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Charlotte (Mom): Tell you wat. Go get Amelia and we'll figure out a plan of action. A movie, maybe. Be . . .

Willow: . . . careful. Yeah, I know. It was March, but still cold enough the ground still crunched under the soles of my boots. Amelia was probably in the woods . . . I hesitated as I came to the edge of the pond. (Pg 472) Right now, for the first time in months, I had no healing fractures, and I planned to keep it that way.

I'd never been allowed on the ice, and like most things that you aren't allowed to do, it was all I thought about. I got down carefully on my hands and knees, and inched forward. I couldn't get hurt ***this*** way.

[Then] there was a moan rippled across the surface of the pond. Suddenly, all around me, the ice became a spiderweb and I was the bug stuck at its center. As the water filled my nose and mouth, I closed my eyes and curled my fists around the things I knew for sure: That I was loved and that this time, it was not me who broke.

Charlotte (Mom): (Pg 475) For a long time, I could only see you sinking. I pictured you, with your skin pale blue and your hair streaming out behind you like a mermaid's. I would wake up screaming, beating the mattress with my hands, as if I could reach through the ice and drag you to safety. . .

I do not have the money anymore. It was yours, after all. I slipped the check into the silk lining of the coffin when I kissed you good-bye for the last time.

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But that wasn't you, no more than the skeleton you'd been given was you. You were more than that, lighter. You were the steam that fogged the mirror in the morning when Sean dragged me out of bed and forced me to take a shower. You were the crystals painting my car windshield after a night's frost. You were the heat rising off the pavement like a ghost in the middle of the summer. You never left me.

Here are the things I know for sure:

- *When you think you're right, you are most likely wrong.*
- *Things that break – be they bones, hearts, or promises – can be put back together but will never really be whole.*
- *And, in spite of what I said, you can miss a person you've never known.*
- *I learn this over and over again, every day I spend without you.*

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AWARD HISTORY

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